Introduction

This research paper combines sociolinguistics and pragmatics to look at the usage of the word “like” in a spoken versus written context. Pragmatics and more specifically comparing written and spoken contexts is commonly studied. These types of studies often focus on syntax, structure, grammar, and more abstractly communicative function. Sociolinguistic studies often focus on uncommon words or phrases and try to get at what influences the structures and usage choices of language. By combining these two areas of research I will focus on the context “like” occurs in, the frequency of usage, grammatical roles, and usage choices to attempt to conclude if “like” is used in a different way in spoken versus written English.

To do this I will use corpus linguistics methods of frequency analysis, collocation, and keyness on two corporas. The first corpus is the Santa Barbara Corpus of Spoken American English (SB Corpus) parts 1-4. This corpus is approximately 249,000 words of primarily natural face to face conversations between speakers who come from a wide range of backgrounds from region, age, occupation, gender, ethnic, and social. The Second corpus I’m using is the Manually Annotated Sub-Corpus (MASC) of contemporary American English written and spoken. MASC has approximately 500,000 words in total and 380,000 of those words are written. Its data is drawn from the Open American National Corpus (OANC) from 19 different genres.

Some examples of relevant previous research are “A corpus-based case study of the highly frequent word 'like'” (Jason Peppard, 2021), “THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN WRITTEN AND SPOKEN ENGLISH”, and “A Sociolinguistic Study of American Slang” (Zhou, Yanchun, and Yanhong Fang) as well as many other focused studies on written and spoken English. “A corpus-based case study of the highly frequent word 'like'” focuses on the semantic usage of “like” by categorizing the usage by grammatical role and then by how it is used, a definition of sorts.

Research Questions

1. Are certain phrases involving “like” (e.g., like you know, like kinda, was like) characteristic of spoken language or written English?
2. How does the overall frequency of “like” differ between spoken and written English?

3. Is “like” used differently in spoken English than in written English?

Methods

To address the research questions my analysis will focus on the word “like” and what contexts it occurs in as well as what other words are associated with its use by doing keyness and collocation analysis. To replicate the code functions I used import the python library Corpus-Tookkit by Kristopher Kyle.

Frequency

To begin analysis I first started by extracting just the written portion of the MASC corpus for subsequent analysis. Then, in python I read the files in and tokenized them, by separating punctuation and words by spaces. I began my analysis by looking at the frequency statistics in both the SB and MASC corporas.

SB
Frequency of like: {'like': 2165, 'liked': 25, 'likes': 23, 'liking': 2, 'likely': 4}
Total occurrences: 2219
total words: 303951
“like” parts per 100,000: 730.0518833627789

MASC
Frequency of like: {'like': 652, 'liked': 17, 'likes': 5, 'liking': 0, 'likely': 74}
Total occurrences: 748
Total words: 389787
“Like” parts per 100,000: 191.8996785423834

This already seems significant as the word “like” has much higher frequency in the spoken corpus compared to the written one even though the two corporas are comparable in size.

Collocation

By performing collocation analysis we can determine what words are most associated with the target word “like”. I did separate collocations of the SB corpus and the MASC corpus. I calculated the strength of association (SOA) and specifically looked

at the tscore to find the most common collocates and then at the faith target cue which tells us the probability of seeing the collocate given the target word. The range of the collocations were 5 hits to the left and to the right of the target with a SOA minimum frequency cutoff of 5.

5 hits left	5 hits right and left	5 hits right
i 17.175633408016424	i 24.525893400793514	a 15.157276952852945
and 17.09349706516549	and 23.43541315041156	you 14.933187396731322
it 14.529143387740362	**h** 22.52151877417301	that 14.44153167986707
h 14.270900830408799	you 22.468656820108258	i 14.398552001320763
you 14.229647133127292	**like** 19.297799573300264	**h** 13.931287908705269
was 13.866745584392781	it 18.969484781178988	**like** 13.116472796796963
like 13.040498231242424	that 18.446876836684165	and 12.767228656920016
its 13.031430357278161	a 18.020624451915346	the 12.570360977055408
know 11.99565408494525	the 17.183810657436258	to 10.442158620252199
just 11.502039164573288	**know** 16.795871320015607	**know** 10.266647342599484

Table 1: SB corpus T-score collocation

5 hits left	5 hits right and left	5 hits right
i 8.695868399893378	a 14.94166236944793	a 12.516003325419883
and 8.382511935484407	the 14.301471557802422	**to** 11.513416006944162
it 7.437707823338232	**to** 13.996184831414062	the 9.880991631390236
is 7.116888741337745	and 11.823635744727428	that 7.41445301880725
the 6.510083946655559	i 11.285361681719863	you 6.881910142616938
would 6.246041751011525	it 9.805049821322664	i 6.095225696735541
a 6.116608447617807	you 9.647841302955445	and 6.088574725252842
you 5.877177154215694	**of** 9.497241583988908	**of** 5.585095204979927
look 5.6670088662811535	that 9.469525794625243	it 5.532334323949254
to 5.444681325954944	**is** 8.962874585909475	this 5.227052277764952

Table 2: MASC corpus T-score collocation

In comparison we can look at the “faith_target_cue” which is the Probability of seeing the collocate given the presence of the target item “like”.

5 hits left	5 hits right and left	5 hits right
i 0.17675651789659744	i 0.31374281926646047	i 0.136986301369863
and 0.173663278833407	and 0.28855501546619533	**h** 0.136986301369863

h 0.14140521431727796	**h** 0.278391515687141	you 0.13521873619089703
you 0.12593901900132567	you 0.26115775519222273	a 0.1303579319487406
it 0.11886875828546177	it 0.18515245249668583	that 0.11886875828546177
was 0.10207688908528502	the 0.1794078656650464	the 0.11665930181175431
like 0.08882015024304021	**like** 0.17852408307556342	and 0.11489173663278833
its 0.08572691117984976	that 0.17764030048608043	**like** 0.0897039328325232
know 0.07865665046398586	a 0.172779496243924	to 0.0760053026955369
just 0.0684931506849315	**know** 0.14007954043305346	it 0.06628369421122404

Table 3: SB corpus faith_target_cue collocation

5 hits left	5 hits right and left	5 hits right
the 0.1450980392156863	the 0.36993464052287583	a 0.24705882352941178
and 0.13856209150326798	a 0.33464052287581697	the 0.22483660130718955
i 0.11895424836601307	**to** 0.30718954248366015	**to** 0.2235294117647059
a 0.08758169934640522	and 0.23137254901960785	and 0.09281045751633987
is 0.08627450980392157	i 0.1869281045751634	that 0.0915032679738562
it 0.08627450980392157	**of** 0.16601307189542483	**of** 0.08496732026143791
to 0.08366013071895424	it 0.13986928104575164	you 0.07712418300653595
of 0.08104575163398693	that 0.13725490196078433	i 0.06797385620915032
in 0.06666666666666667	you 0.13725490196078433	it 0.05359477124183006
you 0.06013071895424837	**is** 0.12549019607843137	in 0.05228758169934641

Table 4: MASC corpus faith_target_cue collocation

<u>Keyness</u>

First I found collocations of four words in the MASC and SB corpus independently. Then, I took each of those dictionaries and filtered them for only entries containing "like". This made the sample size much smaller compared to all the 4 word pairs but still reasonably large.

SB len 437387 —> SB like len 9112

MASC len 380606 —> MASC like len 3176

Then I compared the two corporas, the SB corpus as my target corpus and the MASC corpus as my reference corpus and got the keyness analysis from it. The top 10 outputs for the percent difference, items that only occur in the target corpus (c1), and items that only occur in the reference corpus (c2). Note that negative values in the %diff column mean they're not likely to occur in the target corpus (c1).

%diff	c1_only	c2_only

“or something like that” 540.4907975460121 “would like to have” 42.33128834355826 “it looks like you” -28.834355828220872 “i didnt like the” -28.834355828220872 “what it feels like” -28.834355828220872 “like to ask you” -64.41717791411043 “like the kind of” -64.41717791411043 “it didnt seem like” -64.41717791411043 “sounds like a good” -64.41717791411043	“or something like that” 1937.35873425896 “and i was like” 1614.4656118824669 “and stuff like that” 1183.9414487138092 “i was just like” 968.67936712948 “i would like to” 861.0483263373156 “and it was like” 753.4172855451512 “it was like a” 538.1552039608223 “i dont feel like” 538.1552039608223 “would like to have” 430.5241631686578 “h you know like” 430.5241631686578	“look something like this” 2117.3623714458563 “is likely to be” 1512.4016938898972 “might look like this” 1209.9213551119178 “may look something like” 1209.9213551119178 “it looked like a” 907.4410163339383 “that looked like a” 907.4410163339383 “might look something like” 907.4410163339383 “people like you who” 907.4410163339383 “were more likely to” 907.4410163339383 “would you like to” 907.4410163339383

Table 5: Keyness between SB and MASC 4 word grams

To continue the analysis I did the same process as before but changed the gram size to 2.

%diff	c1_only	c2_only
was like 788.0308880308879 stuff like 574.9034749034751	im like 10081.510081510081 **h** like 7722.007722007722	likely **to** 21135.26570048309 most likely 6642.512077294686

kinda like 574.9034749034751 like they 539.3822393822394 of like 468.33976833976834 its like 366.21621621621625 like what 326.2548262548263 to like 290.7335907335908 but like 184.1698841698842 go like 184.1698841698842	hes like 7507.507507507507 were like 6649.506649506649 **know** like 6649.506649506649 shes like 4933.504933504933 theyre like 3217.5032175032175 have like 3003.003003003003 thats like 3003.003003003003 had like 2788.5027885027885	**is** likely 6642.512077294686 likely that 6038.647342995169 like crazy 3019.3236714975847 are likely 3019.3236714975847 less likely 3019.3236714975847 liked the 3019.3236714975847 unlikely **to** 2415.4589371980674 unlikely that 2415.4589371980674

Table 6: Keyness gram size 2

<u>Concordance</u>

To perform the concordance analysis I used the corp_conc_regex and concor_regex functions from the Corpus-Toolkit. I looked at 50 random hits from each corpus of 5 to the left and 5 to the right of the target word “like”. The SB corpus had 2263 hits in total and the MASC corpus had 766 total hits. Then I categorized how “like” was being used in the sentence into very simple and broad categories: demonstrate (the speaker is describing how to do something), discourse (a filler or hesitation point), compare (comparing two topics), quote (quoting what someone said), pleasure (expressing a positive feeling towards something), and plausible (an action or outcome is plausible).

	Collocate	Label
SB	[[['with', 'weight', 'on', 'your', 'leg'], 'like', ['this', 'do', 'little', 'short', 'extensions']]	Demonstrate

	[['cant', 'have', 'free', 'lunch', 'h'], 'like', ['for', 'my', 'first', 'week', 'there']]	Discourse
	[['that', 'is', 'so=', 'annoy=ing', 'its'], 'like', ['you', 'have', 'to', 'keep', 'eating']]	Compare
	[['have', 'some', 'discussion', 'going', 'on'], 'like', ['sharon:', 'h', 'kathy:', 'give', 'them']]	Quote
	[['like', 'w', 'in', 'what', 'galaxy'], 'like', ['what', 'solar', 'like', 'what', 'what']],	Discourse
	[['h', 'dan:', 'so', 'we', 'got'], 'like', ['three', 'points', 'right', 'here', 'right']],	Discourse
	[['sherry:', '@if', '@it', '2doesnt', 'taste'], 'like', ['clam2', 'rosemary:', '2because', 'eviden2tly', 'fresh']],	Compare
	[['is', 'w=onderful', 'h', 'and', 'something'], 'like', ['this', 'could', 'happen', 'h', 'if']],	Compare
	[['me', 'leanne:', '~liz', 'sort', 'of'], 'like', ['airplane', 'and', 'whats', 'oh', 'plane']],	Compare
	[['h', 'for', 'a', 'given', 'objective'], 'like', ['a', 'labor', 'union', 'if', 'i']],	Compare
	[['one', 'with', 'one', 'you', 'put'], 'like', ['two', 'fourthgraders', 'with', 'h', 'how']],	Discourse
	[['they', 'dont', 'um', 'see', 'any'], 'like', ['direct', 'results', 'for', 'them', 'you']],	Discourse
	[['just', 'little', 'jokey', 'things', 'just'], 'like', ['lisbeth:', 'yeah', 'but', 'thats', 'just']],	Discourse
	[['somebody', 'who', '5makes', 'you', 'feel'], 'like', ['you', 'ha5=ve', 'a', 'responsibility', 'leanne:']],	Compare
	[['her', 'home', 'early', 'and', 'im'], 'like', ['no=', 'lets', 'stay', 'longer', 'but']],	Quote
	[['and', 'it', 'was', 'terrible', 'and'], 'like', ['riding', 'on', 'asphalt', 'so', 'hx']],	Compare
	[['body', 'gets', 'that', 'hot', 'is'], 'like', ['to', 'kill', 'the', 'germs', 'or']],	Discourse
	[['xxxx', '@>', 'chocolate', 'ken:', 'looks'], 'like', ['the', 'kind', 'of', 'thing', 'that']],	Compare
	[['h', 'in', 'the', 'whole=', 'universe'], 'like', ['weve', 'been', 'able', 'to', 'tell']],	Discourse
	[['shes', 'like', 'a', 's=', 'shes'], 'like', ['a', 'walking', 's=keleton', 'ma=n', 'patrick:']],	Compare
	[['thats', 'now', 'a', 'verb', 'thats'], 'like', ['2~ta23=ra', 'said', 'today', 'bill:', 'its']],	Compare
	[['a=ll=', 'the', 'way', 'through', 'vox>'], 'like', ['this', 'nick:', 'yep', 'jed:', 'h']],	Demonstrate
	[['time', 'you', 'see', 'her', 'its'], 'like', ['@>', 'h=', 'you', 'know', 'five']],	Compare
	[['would', 'get', 'it', 'didnt', 'seem'], 'like', ['i', 'could', 'get', 'someone', 'else']],	Compare
	[['id', 'say', 'probably', 'it', 'wasnt'], 'like', ['it', 'was', 'like', 'computers', 'well']],	Compare
	[['happen', 'h', 'plus', 'they', 'didnt'], 'like', ['each', 'other', 'h', 'spar', 'well']],	Pleasure
	[['on', 'but', 'i', 'think', 'probably'], 'like', ['a', 'different', 'car', 'and', 'same']],	Compare
	[['fred:', 'mhm', 'wess:', 'it', 'tastes'], 'like', ['a', 'heath', 'bar', 'fred:', 'mhm']],	Compare
	[['when', '<x', 'i', 'x>2', 'h'], 'like', ['im', 'always=', 'you', 'know', 'ah']],	Discourse
	[['alina:', '<vox', 'and', 'she', 'was'], 'like', ['a', 'real', 'pill', 'you', 'know']],	Compare
	[['coming', 'into', 'the', 'penstocks', 'h'], 'like', ['the', 'one', 'were', 'standing', 'over']],	Discourse

	[['great', 'u=m', 'photographs', 'of', 'of'], 'like', ['um', 'joanne:', 'posters', 'and', 'demos']],	Discourse
	[['her', 'fa=ce', 'dana:', 'mm', 'kelly:'], 'like', ['a', 'stai=n', 'colored', '2birthmark2', 'dana:']],	Compare
	[['h', 'and', 'these', 'guys', 'would'], 'like', ['tickle', 'me=', 'and', 'hug', 'me']],	Discourse
	[['he', 'he', 'ca', 'he3', 'he'], 'like', ['t', 'uh', 'tw', 'takes', 'his']],	Discourse
	[['slapping>>', 'harold:', 'using', 'their', 'hands'], 'like', ['that', 'pete:', '@@@', 'jamie:', '@@@@@']],	Demonstrate
	[['dana:', 'yeah', 'and', 'i', 'was'], 'like', ['kelly:', 'xx', '2<x', 'thing', 'x>2']],	Quote
	[['hard', 'having', 'to', 'hi=de', 'this'], 'like', ['~scotts', 'doing', 'i', 'couldnt', 'hide']],	Compare
	[['new', 'buildings', 'are=', 'i', 'dont'], 'like', ['the', 'new', 'buildings', 'alice:', 'do']],	Pleasure
	[['h', 'i', 'dont', 'like', 'it'], 'like', ['and', 'when', 'i', 'was', 'ho=me']],	Discourse
	[['would', 'you', '@feel', 'but', 'cathlenes'], 'like', ['<@', 'youre', 'not', 'even', 'touching']],	Compare
	[['nick:', 'just', 'like', 'this', 'just'], 'like', ['you', 'would', 'in', 'a', 'regular']],	Demonstrate
	[['later', 'time', 'so', 'its', 'not'], 'like', ['you', 'ha=ve', 'to', 'do', 'it']],	Compare
	[['i', 'know=', 'jill:', 'there', 'arent'], 'like', ['parties', 'now', 'jeff:', 'tsk', '@@@@@@']],	Discourse
	[['strong', 'enough', 'so', 'you', 'could'], 'like', ['nancy:', 'you', 'knew', 'they', 'werent']],	Discourse
	[['keys', 'jennifer:', 'no', 'i', 'need'], 'like', ['a', 'little', 'pin', 'or', 'something']],	Discourse
	[['thats', 'real', 'icing', 'kendra:', 'i'], 'like', ['like', 'wedding', 'cake2s', 'kevin:', 'right']],	Pleasure
	[['dana:', 'but', 'i', 'dont', 'feel'], 'like', ['making', '2it', 'kelly:', '2<x', 'think']],	Compare
	[['those', 'the', 'ones', 'that', 'dont'], 'like', ['people', 'the', 'handsoff', 'ones', 'kirsten:']],	Pleasure
	[['like', 'goofing', 'around', 'and', 'stuff'], 'like', ['that', 'lajuan:', 'mhm', 'cam:', 'h']]]	Compare
MASC	[[['the', 'room', 'after', 'what', 'feels'], 'like', ['an', 'eternity', 'with', 'promises', 'of']],	Compare
	[['the', 'other', 'bursar:', 'its', 'not'], 'like', ['that', 'sir', 'this', 'ship', 'is']],	Compare
	[['may', 'be', 'flourishing', 'elsewhere', 'and'], 'like', ['a', 'virus', 'theyre', 'just', 'waiting']],	Compare
	[['europeans', 'mostly', 'manifest', 'as', 'something'], 'like', ['the', 'underground', 'society', 'of', 'your']],	Compare
	[['the', 'refined', 'world', 'of', 'print'], 'like', ['a', 'surly', 'foreigner', 'among', 'a']],	Compare
	[['the', 'rifle', 'fire', 'that', 'war'], 'like', ['others', 'produced', 'disgruntled',	Compare

	'veterans', 'and']],	
	[['relatives', 'in', 'actual', 'fact', 'i'], 'like', ['your', 'motherinlaw', 'a', 'whole', 'lot']],	Pleasure
	[['p', 'the', 'independent', 'filmmaking', 'industry'], 'like', ['the', 'silicon', 'valley', 'the', 'independent']],	Compare
	[['industrial', 'complex', 'it', 'had', 'seemed'], 'like', ['such', 'a', 'great', 'base', 'of']],	Compare
	[['me', 'know', 'what', 'you', 'would'], 'like', ['to', 'do', 'fyii', 'will', 'be']],	Pleasure
	[['subroutine', 'and', 'may', 'look', 'something'], 'like', ['this:', 'ant', 'identification', 'identifies', 'an']],	Compare
	[['ruffles', 'at', 'the', 'throat', 'things'], 'like', ['that', 'he', 'really', 'stood', 'out']],	Compare
	[['have', 'to', 'find', 'people', 'you'], 'like', ['who', 'make', 'movies', 'it's', 'getting']],	Pleasure
	[['john', 'hammond', 'contd', 'id', 'also'], 'like', ['to', 'thank', 'the', 'three', 'of']],	Pleasure
	[['oulu', 'weather:', 'fair', 'c', 'feels'], 'like', ['humidity:', 'winds:', 'kmhr', 'n', 'http:tinyurlcom3fjbg2']],	Compare
	[['wife', 'asked', 'how', 'would', 'you'], 'like', ['it', 'if', 'you', 'didnt', 'see']],	Pleasure
	[['of', 'taste', 'i', 'happen', 'to'], 'like', ['all', 'three', 'the', 'buildings', 'are']],	Pleasure
	[['anything', 'for', 'you', 'to', 'look'], 'like', ['that', 'while', 'thinking', 'about', 'me']],	Compare
	[['much', 'about', 'what', 'suffocating', 'felt'], 'like', ['thats', 'when', 'i', 'heard', 'a']],	Compare
	[['its', 'radio', 'masts', 'stick', 'up'], 'like', ['an', 'insect's', 'antennae', 'the', 'rival']],	Compare
	[['we', 'have', 'never', 'needed', 'members'], 'like', ['you', 'more', 'we', 'need', 'your']],	Compare
	[['a', 'straight', 'up', 'misrepresentation', 'its'], 'like', ['saying', 'i', 'didnt', 'kick', 'the']],	Compare
	[['the', 'only', 'one', 'who', 'thinks'], 'like', ['i', 'do', 'who', 'understands', 'this']],	Compare
	[['historical', 'evidence', 'that', 'says', 'people'], 'like', ['zombies', 'but', 'also', 'partly', 'on']],	Pleasure
	[['top', 'of', 'the', 'black', 'fort'], 'like', ['a', 'gold', 'headed', 'monster', 'tucker']],	Compare
	[['as', 'a', 'result', 'upjohn', 'will'], 'likely', ['trim', 'only', 'about', 'to', 'of']],	Plausable
	[['path', 'to', 'renewed', 'economic', 'strength'], 'like', ['so', 'many', 'americans', 'we', 'began']],	Compare
	[['stay', 'so', 'healthy', 'you', 'look'], 'like', ['a', '60yearold', 'well', 'my', 'wife']],	Compare
	[['rooting', 'against', 'him', 'sounds', 'just'], 'like', ['alex', 'rodriguez', 'doesnt', 'it', 'im']],	Compare
	[['exposed', 'the', 'effect', 'will', 'be'], 'like', ['that', 'downstream', 'of', 'the',	Compare

	'axis']],	
	[['oulu', 'weather:', 'fair', 'c', 'feels'], 'like', ['humidity:', 'winds:', 'kmhr', 'n', 'http:tinyurlcom3fjbg2']],	Compare
	[['so', 'what's', 'the', 'cat', 'look'], 'like', ['he', 'turned', 'to', 'me', 'nepthys']],	Compare
	[['to', 'be', 'brainwashed', 'this', 'felt'], 'like', ['a', 'science', 'project', 'gone', 'wrong']],	Compare
	[['run', 'childrens', 'homes', 'little', 'ones'], 'like', ['baby', 'jessica', 'caught', 'in', 'the']],	Compare
	[['when', 'we', 'lose', 'a', 'member'], 'like', ['you', 'it', 'hurts', 'all', 'of']],	Compare
	[['eyelids', 'were', 'painted', 'to', 'look'], 'like', ['open', 'eyes', 'will', 'turner:', 'jack']],	Compare
	[['me', 'know', 'if', 'you', 'would'], 'like', ['me', 'to', 'call', 'you', 'email']],	Pleasure
	[['marcia', 'whited', 'at', 'we', 'would'], 'like', ['to', 'have', 'families', 'matched', 'with']],	Pleasure
	[['<bluewaterrubbers@hotmailcom>', 'dear', 'sirmadam', 'would', 'you'], 'like', ['to', 'work', 'online', 'from', 'home']],	Pleasure
	[['obese', 'to', 'being', 'normal', 'would'], 'likely', ['show', 'changes', 'in', 'yhl', 'but']],	Plausable
	[['fair', 'park', 'pond', 'or', 'something'], 'like', ['that:', 'http:wigspherecom', 'thoughts', 'from', 'michael']],	Compare
	[['a', 'gently', 'grasping', 'my', 'hips'], 'like', ['he', 'is', 'lifting', 'up', 'a']],	Compare
	[['the', 'code', 'may', 'look', 'something'], 'like', ['this:', 'exit', 'nest', 'uses', 'temperature']],	Compare
	[['one', 'of', 'those', 'funny', 'words'], 'like', ['weasel', 'or', 'chainsaw', 'celebrate', 'the']],	Compare
	[['and', 'fear', 'that', 'the', 'most'], 'likely', ['victim', 'will', 'be', 'the', 'science']],	Plausable
	[['liver', 'function', 'tests', 'were', 'more'], 'likely', ['to', 'have', 'lung', 'kidney', 'or']],	Plausable
	[['never', 'to', 'meet', 'this', 'person'], 'like', ['me', 'is', 'not', 'a', 'member']],	Compare
	[['salt', 'flats', 'and', 'he', 'immediately'], 'liked', ['karnes', 'who', 'showed', 'him', 'around']],	Pleasure
	[['of', 'caring', 'and', 'concerned', 'people'], 'like', ['you', 'audubon', 'won', 'a', 'temporary']],	Compare
	[['tell', 'about', 'this', 'product:', 'i'], 'like', ['how', 'quick', 'this', 'product', 'worked']],	Pleasure
	[['descriptive—of', 'those', 'we', 'do', 'not'], 'like', ['at', 'least', 'safire', 'expresses', 'an']]]	Pleasure

Table 6: Concordance of "like"

The categories I used to identify the different uses of like are very loose going mostly by intuition than strict rules and as such would need to be double checked and

properly defined. My intuition tells me that within categories there are other more subtle meanings. However, I trust my results enough to conclude that “like” is used as a discourse marker in a spoken context and most likely not in a written. To further this and find more concrete findings it would be best to define more rigid rules of defining like in “The Lexical Syllabus and English Language Coursebooks: A Corpus-Based Case Study of the Highly Frequent Word ‘Like.’” by Jason Peppard pictured below:

Table 1.1: Summary of entries for *like* in the OED, ordered by frequency. Regional and obsolete entries have been omitted. Sub-senses have also been omitted due to space limitations.

	Part of speech	**Frequency per million**	**Etymology**	**Definition**
like$_1$	adj., adv., conj., prep.	100–999	early Scandinavian	(1) similar, resembling, alike (2) probable, likely and related senses
like$_2$	verb$_1$	100–999	Germanic	to take pleasure in or be pleased by something
like$_3$	noun$_1$	1–9.9	LIKE adj.	something of the same kind as that previously mentioned or implied
like$_4$	verb$_2$	1–9.9	LIKE adj.	to compare; to imitate
like$_5$	noun$_2$	0.1–0.99	LIKE verb$_1$	(1) a feeling of regard, preference, or affection for something or someone; a predilection (2) in the context of social media: an expression of approval or support made by clicking on a particular icon
like$_6$	suffix	not provided	LIKE adj.	(1) forming adjectives with the sense “similar to or of the nature of—,” “characteristic of or befitting—" (2) forming adverbs with the sense “in or after the manner of—,” “so as to resemble—" (3) forming adjectives with the sense “resembling, or characteristic of, a person who or thing which is—; having the appearance of being—" (4) forming adverbs with the sense “in a—manner; with the appearance of being—"

Image 1

Findings

From the frequency data the occurrences of “like” and its lemmas was much higher in the spoken corpus compared to the written one. This implies that “like” might be more productive in spoken language. To explore this further I started by doing collocation analysis. From the collocation analysis I found that [“h”, “like”, “know”] were collocates that only occurred in the SB corpus of spoken English. Important to note is the “h” is a representation for aspiration during speech. Also interesting to note is the double use of “like” implied with “like” being a collocate to itself. Comparatively, the written portion of the MASC corpus had [“is”, “to”, “of”] as unique collocates.

To further explore the contexts that “like” occurs in, I compared the SB corpus as the target and the MASC corpus as the reference to perform keyness analysis. From the keyness analysis I found that in the four word grams like was used most often to create a comparative construction “x like y”. Notably, in none of the top 10 key phrases that were exclusive to the spoken corpus was “like” used as a discourse marker. Then by looking at just two word grams (“like” and one other word) in table 6 the aspiration “h like” was very key to the spoken corpus compared to the written. Key phrases to the written corpus were more likely to use “likely” than the base form “like”.

From the concordance analysis and hand tagging the usage of “like” in each eleven word snippet it was revealed that “like” seemed to be used in a more progressive way, aka in more contexts in spoken English than in written as displayed in the table below.

SB Counts	MASC Counts
Compare: 22	Compare: 34
Discourse: 17	Pleasure: 13
Demonstrate: 4	Plausable: 4
Pleasure: 4	
Quote: 3	

Table 7: Environmental Counts

This gives reasonable proof that “like” can mean different things and is used differently in a spoken compared to written context of English.

Research Questions

1. Are certain phrases involving “like” (e.g., like you know, like kinda, was like) characteristic of spoken language or written English?
   Within five hits of the word “like”, “know” was a collocate in the SB corpus but not in the MACS corpus this means a phrase similar to “like you know” could be more likely or unique to spoken English. The top three two word phrases that were key to the SB corpus were [“im like”, “h like”, “hes like”] and the top three in the MASC corpus were [“likely to”, “most likely”, “is likely”]. This shows that there are certain two word phrases that are unique to each context but they may not be what was expected to be significant.

2. How does the overall frequency of “like” differ between spoken and written English?
   “Like” occurs much more frequently in the spoken corpus than in the written one by about 54% (total occurrences of like /total words: SB 0.73% - 0.19% for MASC). It also is much more productive in the spoken corpus occurring in more constructions.

3. Is “like” used differently in spoken English than in written English?
   From the collocation analysis and from other words and phrases that are unique to spoken and written English, yes, it seems that the word “like” can be used differently in spoken English than it can be in written English.

Conclusion

Similar to Jason Peppard's more detailed summary of the definitions of “like” in image one, my written corpus MASC also has comparative uses as the most frequent followed by “like” used as a verb to express pleasure as the second most frequent. Similar to other research on spoken vs written English I also found that “like” was used in different ways between the two. This implies that even on the word level written and spoken language can differ.

The limitations of my study are as follows; my corporas are not perfect because they are on the smaller side being less than one million words and sections from the full collection of data. The t-scores for the MASC corpus were lower than the SB corpus and many were not above ten which means they weren't necessarily “strong” collocates. When doing the four word grams in the keyness analysis the length of hits reduced by a significant amount. And finally my tagging in the concordance analysis is not perfect and has not been checked by someone else. The tags themselves are also very general and mostly intuition driven than hard set rules which can not be considered reliable. I also can not continue this analysis as I would need to train a PLM to identify the roles for all the hits of “like” in each corpus to be able to analyze the distributions of these uses more.

Along the same lines for future research training a PLM to identify the roles of like to be able to conclude more reliably the distributions and usages of like in a written and spoken context. More specific tokens that include like could be used in collocation or keyness analysis to further look into unique usages of “like”. It would also be helpful to find a bigger corpus or different one in general to compare the findings to, for example if in a different spoken corpus “like” is used in the same ways as in the SB corpus.

The usages of “like” do differ in a spoken and written context. “Like” is overall more frequent in a spoken corpus and used more productively. “Like” was used to express comparisons, discourse constructions, demonstrate things, as a marker of pleasure, and to quote someone talking. Most notably the Santa Barbara corpus marks aspiration with a “h” which was unique to the spoken context and frequently occurring.

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